The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology (Guangzhou)

UCUG3801- Social Inequality and Social Mobility

1 September 2026 – 17 December 2026

Updated on 14 August 2026

[Course Title] Social Inequality and Social Mobility

[Course Code] UCUG3801

[No. of Credits] 3

[Any pre-/co-requisites] No

Instructors: Zhuoni Zhang; Muzhi ZHOU (MZ)

Venue and Time (L01 (6358)+ T01 (6360)): Rm 221, W1, WE 3:00 PM – 05:50 PM

Venue and Time (L02 (6359)+ T02 (6361)): Rm 102, W1, TH 09:00 AM – 11:50 AM

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Course Description

Social stratification concerns the unequal distribution of resources/rewards/opportunities which are scarce but widely desired, and the process of status attainment or social mobility whereby some persons or groups come to receive more of these scarce things than are received by others. This course will introduce the basic concepts and theories in analyzing social and economic inequalities in the contemporary world.

Intended Learning Outcomes (ILOs)

By the end of this course, students should be able to:

1	Describe the similarities and differences in key concepts, measures and theories that are used in analyzing social and economic inequality
2	Explain the key factors and processes of how inequality is created, and social mobility is achieved, especially in the context of Hong Kong and mainland China.
3	Describe the consequences of inequality and propose public policies to tackle the issues

Weekly schedule & Weekly ILOs

Lecture #	Topics	Weekly ILOs
1	Introduction and overview	ILO-3
2	Theories, Trends, Patterns	ILO-1, ILO-2
3	Three Capitals and Educational Achievement	ILO-1, ILO-2
4	Social Class and Social Mobility	ILO-1, ILO-2, ILO-3
5	Economic Inequality	ILO-1, ILO-2
6	Race, Ethnicity, and Inequality	ILO-1, ILO-2
7	Globalization and Migration	ILO-1, ILO-2, ILO-3
8	Gender, Sexuality, and Inequality	ILO-2, ILO-3
9	Education, Migration and Hukou	ILO-1, ILO-2, ILO-3
10	Technology and Social Orders	ILO-1, ILO-2
11	Consequences and Policy Implications	ILO-1, ILO-2, ILO-3
12	Round table (Date TBD)	ILO-1, ILO-2, ILO-3
13	Group Project Presentation	ILO-1, ILO-2, ILO-3

Assessment and Grading

This course will be assessed using criterion-referencing, and grades will not be assigned using a curve. Detailed rubrics for each assignment, outlining the criteria used for evaluation, are provided below.

Assessments:

Assessment Task	Contribution to Overall Course grade (%)	Due date
[1] Course participation	20	Progress with the course
[2] Discussion leadership	15	Progress with the course
[3] Written Assignment	20	Individual essays due date
[4] Learning portfolio	20	Progress with the course.
[5] Group project	25	In-class group presentation (week 13)

* Assessment marks for individual assessed tasks will be released within two weeks of the due date.

Mapping of Course ILOs to Assessment Tasks

Assessed Task	Mapped ILOs	Explanation
[1] Course participation	[ILO1, ILO2]	Frequent **in-class interactive activities** and **field trips**, such as Q&A and quizzes, will examine students' understanding of the topics introduced in class. [ILO-1 and ILO-2]
[2] Discussion leadership	[ILO1, ILO2, ILO3]	Students act as **discussion leaders** to guide their peers in their group or the class in debates and discussions. [ILO1, ILO2, ILO3]
[3] Written assignment	[ILO1, ILO2, ILO3]	**Two individual essays** will enhance the students' ability to use the concepts learnt and to reflect deeper about this course. [ILO1, ILO2, ILO3]
[4] Learning portfolio	[ILO1, ILO2, ILO3]	**Weekly discussion leader report** and one small **group poster submission** following the field trip will help students develop their ability to explain the reasons behind the social inequality and mobility terms introduced in class and experienced firsthand. [[ILO1, ILO-2, ILO-3]
[5] Group Project	[ILO1, ILO2, ILO3]	A final term group **research project** will enhance their ability to work in a team, improve their presentation skills, and develop their ability to apply concepts to real-life cases. [ILO1, ILO2, ILO3]

Grading Rubrics

Assessment Task	A high grade means
[1] Course participation	- A good attendance record; - Active participation in proposing questions or answering questions; - Participation in our field trips, data collection, and engagement with local residents.
[2] Discussion leadership	- Actively voice their own viewpoints and engage with other peers or the teacher to guide the discussion either for the entire class or each individual group; - Engage with others in a polite, honest, and critical way; - On-time submission of the group's weekly summary of in-class discussion activity

	- Lead the group to achieve a high mark when there is a competition
[3] Written assignment	Two short essays based on selected topics with own insights. - Timely submission; showing efforts in weekly readings and the ability to develop an argument. - A creative and critical writing style - Presenting logical, specific writing with a sharp viewpoint and solid evidence, showcasing extensive reading and critical thinking abilities with sufficient and highly relevant data support - Writing should demonstrate the ability to apply concepts and theories to daily observations, with proper citations, insights from the readings, and personal reflections. - Writing that is *not driven* by Large Language Models (LLMs)
[4] Learning portfolio	- A good summary of discussion group's discussion process and outcomes. - Field trip poster showcasing reasonable data collection efforts for a selected topic - Field trip poster showcasing the ability to tell synthesis a story about social inequality and mobility
[5] Group Project	A group project with a suggested number of members. **Presentation component:** A clear and confident presentation involving all team members, with solid content (evidence-based) and proper citations; a professional presentation that engages with the audience and does not focus on reading the words on the PPT slides. **Written component**: The presentation slides that contain the question, the data, the results, and the conclusion; and a short written self-reflection of their group project (before and after, what they have learnt by doing this project)

*More details with be given in class after the announcement of the detailed assignment requirements.

Final Grade Descriptors:

Grades	Short Description	Elaboration on subject grading description
A	Excellent Performance	Demonstrates a comprehensive grasp of subject matter, expertise in concept-explanation, and **significant critical and creative thinking** on pressing social issues. Exhibits a high capacity for scholarship and collaboration, going beyond core requirements to achieve learning goals.
B	Good Performance	Shows good knowledge and understanding of the main subject matter, competence in problem construction, and the ability to analyze and evaluate issues. Displays high motivation to learn and the ability to work effectively with others.
C	Satisfactory Performance	Possesses adequate knowledge of core subject matter, competence in dealing with familiar problems, and some capacity

		for analysis and critical thinking. Shows persistence and effort to achieve broadly defined learning goals.
D	Marginal Pass	Has threshold knowledge of core subject matter, potential to achieve key professional skills, and the ability to make basic judgments. Benefits from the course and has the potential to develop in the discipline.
F	Fail	Demonstrates insufficient understanding of the subject matter and lacks the necessary problem-solving skills. Shows limited ability to think critically or analytically and exhibits minimal effort towards achieving learning goals.

Course AI Policy

This course allows the usage of AI to facilitate language editing. Notably, writing should **never** be dominated or led by AI language agents. Content without substantive content, specific details, correct citations, or sharp arguments **will be penalized**.

Communication and Feedback

Assessment marks for individual assessed tasks will be communicated via Canvas within two weeks of submission. Feedback on assignments will include [specific details, e.g., strengths, areas for improvement]. Students who have further questions about the feedback, including marks, should consult the instructor within five working days after the feedback is received.

Resubmission Policy

Make-up submissions are granted only under exceptional circumstances for which the student provides a documented and acceptable excuse (i.e., unforeseen illness, family emergency, etc.).

Required Texts and Materials

	Details *(title, author, publisher, publication year, web address etc.)*	**Library Availability**
1	**David Grusky. (2018) The Inequality Reader Contemporary and Foundational Readings in Race, Class, and Gender**	**Available – short loan (TBD) / Separate chapters will be available via Canvas**
2	**李强. (2019). 当代中国社会分层 (第 1 版.). 生活・讀書・新知三联书店.**	**HN740.Z9 S6352**

[Optional] Additional Resources

	Details *(title, author, publisher, publication year, web address etc.)*	**Library Availability**
1	**Coleman, J.S. (1990) Foundations of Social Theory, Harvard University Press.**	**HM24 .C65 1994**

Academic Integrity

Students are expected to adhere to the university's academic integrity policy. Students are expected to uphold HKUST(GZ)'s Academic Honor Code and to maintain the highest standards for academic integrity. The University has zero tolerance of academic misconduct. Please refer to the Regulations for Academic Integrity and Student Conduct for the University's definition of plagiarism and ways to avoid cheating and plagiarism.

Additional readings will be posted on CANVAS

** This is a tentative outline of the course. As such, we reserve the right to make changes.*